

Visions of Destruction

Mar Canet Sola
mar.canet@gmail.com
Tallinn University
Tallinn, Estonia

Varvara Guljajeva
varvarag@ust.hk
Hong Kong University of Science and Technology
Guangzhou, China



ABSTRACT

"Visions of Destruction" is an interactive AI-aided artwork that critiques the human impact on the environment. A viewer's gaze, detected by an eye-tracking sensor, causes transformations in the landscape imagery. Hence, merely by observing the digital scenery, the spectator induces dramatic changes at the points their gaze touches.

AI-generated 'beautiful landscapes', constructed by Stable Diffusion, present viewers with a romanticized version of nature derived from the collective human memory, as represented by a web-based

training dataset. The piece operates in real-time, providing a unique experience for each viewer, symbolizing the Anthropocene and the urgency to protect the natural environment. A viewer's gaze acts as a metaphor for human presence and the irreversible actions leading to today's climate crisis.

Technically speaking, an eye-tracker registers the gaze, which then triggers an image change precisely where the audience's eyes land. Using an array of pre-set prompts and inpainting with Stable Diffusion, viewers witness how pristine nature begins to deform before their eyes. Consequently, participants can reshape mountains, carve rivers, erect cities, and disrupt the initial idyllic nature, experiencing the metaphorical destruction and tension between technology and nature. When the eye-tracking detects no viewers, the landscapes begin a regeneration journey. Nature finds solace in this symbiotic dance between human presence and absence, its beauty flourishing. Additionally, the project brings interactivity into the realm of AI art.

Permission to make digital or hard copies of part or all of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).

SA Art Gallery '23, December 12-15, 2023, Sydney, NSW, Australia

© 2023 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).

ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-0308-9/23/12.

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3610537.3622947>

The artwork effectively utilises generative models to emphasize the urgency of the climate crisis. By transitioning from serene landscapes to scenes of ecological devastation, it captures the stark realities of our evolving world. This aligns with the audience's crucial role in molding our environment and highlights everyone's

duty to nature. As such, "Visions of Destruction" stands not only as artwork but also as a call to action.

ACM Reference Format:

Mar Canet Sola and Varvara Guljajeva. 2023. Visions of Destruction . In *Proceedings of SA Art Gallery '23*. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 2 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3610537.3622947>